

This Is Your Brain on Porn



By Karen Kropf

This Is Your Brain on Porn



By Karen Kropf

This Is Your Brain on Porn

Copyright © 2014 by Karen Kropf

ISBN (978-1-63443-874-2)

Smashwords Edition

Copyright © 2014 Karen Kropf

All Rights Reserved

This eBook is licensed for your personal enjoyment only. This eBook may not be re-sold or given away to other people. If you would like to share this book with another person, please purchase an additional copy for each person you share it with. If you're reading this book and did not purchase it, or it was not purchased for your use only, then you should return to Smashwords.com and purchase your own copy. Thank you for respecting the hard work of this author.

Print version of This is Your Brain on Porn available [here](#)

Discover other ebooks by Karen Kropf

Raising Teens With Sexual-Self Control: A Parent's Survival Guide

Sex Makes People Stupid: How to Avoid Ending Up With a Loser

www.PositivelyWaiting.com

~~~~~

## **Dedication**

To those who struggle with porn, and the people who love them.

~~~~~

Table of Contents

[Foreword](#)

[Author's Note](#)

[Introduction](#)

[Chapter 1 You'd Have To Be Blind](#)

[Chapter 2 The Four Big Lies](#)

[Chapter 3 Sexual Superglue](#)

[Chapter 4 Chemical Cocktails](#)

[Chapter 5 Rewiring Your Brain](#)

[Chapter 6 Brain Changer Toolkit](#)

[Chapter 7 Don't Do It Alone](#)

[Chapter 8 Fight FOR Something](#)

[Chapter 9 Don't Give Up](#)

[Chapter 10 You Can't Disappoint God](#)

~~~~~

## [Foreword](#)

The standard my guy friends and I had was, “It’s okay to look, as long as you don’t touch.” Then my bride caught me watching porn and started crying.

No one ever warned me I would crave those images I saw - even years later! What was wrong with me? The desire for porn just wouldn’t leave. Not without a fight.

No one will challenge your thinking about porn more than Karen Kropf. She is a master communicator who has interacted with thousands of high schoolers, college students and young bachelors. I should know. I used to tell my own story right alongside her in the classroom.

Yeah, it’s a book about porn written by a woman — but Karen is like a good cook. She invites you in, feeds you something unexpected, and you’re surprised to discover it was awesome!

If you read this book all the way to the end, you’ll find the help you’re looking for.

You can be an overcomer, too.

Chris Conant,

*Entrepreneur and overcomer*



~~~~~

[Author's note](#)

I have made every effort to protect and respect confidentiality. All names are fictitious, and all identifying characteristics have been altered so that any resemblance to an actual person is entirely coincidental.

~~~~~

## Introduction

The impact of pornography on education or career decisions and relationships can be devastating. I'm guessing you know that, because you're reading this book. It's a pretty safe assumption that you or someone you care about needs help.

Every pornographic image is permanently burned into the brain's hard drive. It will always be there, and there will always be a pathway that leads to it, whether you want one or not.

This little book is hardly the definitive work on the subject. Still, it will help you understand how porn works on the brain, and what can be done to reprogram it.

But I'm not going to sugarcoat this: It will be difficult. For many people, too difficult. So to keep your sanity and frustration to a minimum, just start by accepting there will be failures. When it happens, please repeat this mantra,

*Every day is fresh with no mistakes in it. I can start over.*

~~~~

Chapter 1: You'd Have To Be Blind

In December of 2013 the following statistics related to porn use were published by ProjectKnow:

>>>42% of male college students said they visited porn sites “regularly.”

>>>64% said that their tastes in porn “have become more extreme or deviant.”

>>>53% said they developed a porn habit between the ages of 12 and 14.

>>>16% say they started before 12.

These days, porn is everywhere and you can’t get away from it, even when you try. There is soft porn and more “just a click away.”

As a result, young people are growing up believing there is a segment of the population perpetually and instantly ready for sex. They are convinced magical creatures exist who will never ask a guy to talk about his feelings (at least not beyond “does this feel good?”)

While it is increasingly more common for females to struggle with porn-addictions, it is primarily males who are the target consumer.

Porn preys on two specific male traits. First, that the male sexual response is visually driven. Males are stimulated by what they see. And second, that male sexual nature craves MORE. Not just more often, but more variety.

Few guys understand that female sexual nature isn't visually driven. While she may appreciate seeing nicely shaped legs, it doesn't do the same thing for her that nice legs do for him. Her system is much more complicated and requires concentration in order for the magical things to happen.

The whole operation takes effort for her, unlike his sexual response system which is automatic. Male sexual appetite operates at maximum capacity 24/7. That's just the way guys are wired. It's physical, visceral and specific. And there's nothing he can do about it. An orgasm takes very little work. So when there is an opportunity to feel really good without much exertion, he reasons, "Why not?"

Porn exploits these two aspects of male nature by fostering a belief in Four BIG Lies.

- 1) Porn doesn't hurt me.
- 2) Porn doesn't hurt anyone else.
- 3) Porn helps me understand the opposite sex.

4) Porn will be unnecessary once I am in a satisfying relationship.

Let's deal with each lie individually.

~~~

## **Chapter 2: The Four Big Lies**

*Porn cost Michael the opportunity of a lifetime. Tasked with a deadline for a movie deal, Michael habitually clicked on porn to “relieve his writer’s block.” He had “writer’s block” so often that he failed to complete the script in time. The studio went with another writer.*

\*\*\*

### **Porn doesn’t hurt me.**

Every time you look at porn you engage in self-destructive behavior. It literally saps your productivity and creativity. The first image pulls you to the next and the next. Time to accomplish worthwhile things gets away. It is easy to click on an image and suddenly realize two hours have passed.

The temporary relief or pleasure from porn is often followed by disgust or distress, which makes you look for something that makes you feel better... like porn.

### **Porn doesn’t hurt anyone else.**

Porn is directly responsible for sex-trafficking. Children are abducted, addicted and sold to make porn. Once they are “in the life,” there is little chance they will get out until they are “too old” to be used.

Porn also contributes to the increase of sexually transmitted infections, and spawns child abuse, spousal assault and chemical dependence. Despite what you

tell yourself you're seeing, the people engaged in the act often have to be high to perform.

If there were no consumers, porn would cease.

### **Porn helps me understand the opposite sex.**

Porn-users rarely have relationships with REAL people that don't fail. Because the desire for sex overwhelms any desire for true intimacy.

Understanding another person's hopes, fears and aspirations requires focused attention, active listening and selflessness. None of these skills can be developed through porn.

Porn teaches you how to use people to meet your needs. It increases your expectation that others exist to serve you. Pretty soon humans are just objects to be consumed and discarded like litter.

### **Porn will be unnecessary once I am in a satisfying relationship.**

Many porn users want to believe that, but the opposite is true. No real human being will ever measure up to an airbrushed, well-paid porn star. Porn-watchers are constantly drawn back to their fantasy cyberversions of perfection. A virtual person who can be switched on or off at will.



There are NO real men or women like that. None. The more porn you put in your head, the less satisfied you will be with the real thing when you do find it.

If there is a relationship, it's unlikely the porn-user will grasp how watching porn hurts their partner. Girlfriends and wives are often plagued by feelings of inadequacy, trying to understand how someone who says "I love you" would rather have virtual sex with an imitation instead of the Real Thing with them.

The distorted view presented in porn often convinces the user there is something "wrong" with his partner because she isn't instantly and perpetually available for sex.

If you want more information on the destructive impact of pornography, check out [ProjectKnow.com](http://ProjectKnow.com).

The damage to relationships and well-being isn't just psychological, it's also physiological.

Let me explain how porn impacts brain chemistry.

~~~

[Chapter 3: Sexual Superglue](#)

Eric was molested by a neighbor when he was 8. His abuser introduced him to porn. As an adult, he found relationships with women got boring pretty quickly, causing him to cheat or move on to someone else.

First-time sex for boys is similar to what happens with baby ducks. When a baby duck hatches, it “imprints” on the first creature it sees, which triggers the instinct to follow. Usually the mommy duck is sitting right there, so the little duckling imprints and follows her everywhere for the first several weeks of life, while she teaches him how to be a healthy happy duck.

But imprinting is instinctive behavior that can’t be changed, so it can go horribly wrong. If the first thing the little duck sees is a DOG, it will follow the dog.

It can happen to boys, too.

Until about age 25, the brain’s prefrontal cortex isn’t fully developed. This is the area responsible for planning, organization, complex thinking and impulse control. Until neural connections to this Reasoning Center are finished, the amygdala, where emotional memory is centered, runs the show.

During puberty, the brain has an explosion of neural growth. Many more cells than can possibly survive. The skull only has so much space and nutrients available. It causes a fierce competition. Brain cells and connections literally fight for their survival, and only a small percentage will make it.

This is how it gets hard-wired. Behaviors during adolescence which are repeated develop strong neural connections while networks related to tasks done infrequently atrophy and disappear.

Think of neural networks as hiking trails across a field. The more often people use the trail, the easier it is to find. Lots of hikers and it becomes a bike path. Pretty soon, it gets paved. Next, it gets widened into a two lane road. Then four. Eventually, it will become a superhighway.

Constructing a neural network for sex functions just like that. Let's say a boy's first sexual experience is at her house when her parents are gone. He's afraid they might get caught. He's worried she might change her mind. He's nervous that he isn't "doing it right."

Then whoosh! his brain floods with dopamine, a hormone that stimulates his Pleasure Center. It's like a tsunami. It affects him from the top of his head to the soles of his feet and it imprints, not on her, but on the emotions surrounding the event. The fear, danger and risk.

Over the next few days he remembers, relives and replays that event again and again. Every time he does, the association between the exhilaration of sex and fear, danger and risk will get stronger.

Add to that, hours of playing video games where he gets "buff points" for sexual violence, listening to songs with sexually suggestive lyrics, and watching porn when no one is home.

It doesn't take long for his neural network to go from a deer trail to a superhighway.

Unchecked, this boy grows into an adult male who cannot be sexually satisfied without fear, danger and risk. This is the guy who has risky sex, unprotected sex, multiple concurrent partners, unfaithful sex... and he can't even tell you WHY he does it.

He has no idea his brain is trying to repeat that first experience burned into his hard drive.

The superhighway to Pleasure City will never disappear. Even if he stops using it. It might get overgrown, but it will always be there, just underneath the vegetation.

And that's the tip of the iceberg as far as what's going on in the brain!

~~~

#### **Chapter 4: Chemical Cocktails**

*To satisfy, Patrick's porn use became more bizarre and degrading. Recurring nightmares about sadomasochism and sexual torture caused him to become sleep deprived. He couldn't do his job. Sometimes he "saw" things when no one was there. His girlfriend couldn't take it, and left.*

\*\*\*

Brain cells communicate with each other using neurotransmitters. These are protein molecules are mixed together to form different chemical concoctions. They are the messengers between cells which produce the physiological part of an emotional experience.

These various concoctions float across the gap between cells and are detected by neuroreceptors on the cells across the way. Every cell has thousands of them.

Individual neurotransmitters have their own specific neuroreceptor. Meaning anger receptors only pay attention to the anger mixtures, distress receptors only recognize distress mixtures, etc. Anger receptors can't detect a distress potion.

Plus each one is very specific: irritation and rage are both forms of anger, but they don't produce the same chemical combination.

So it works like this: Someone cuts you off in traffic. It triggers an emotion: irritation. That causes your brain cells to release an irritation tonic. For the sake of clarity we'll call it "Sasparilla."

*Sasparilla floats over to another cell. The Sasparilla receptors on the opposite cell recognize their favorite drink! Let's party!*

If your brain keeps thinking about the guy who cut you off, the cell with the Sasparilla receptors will produce even more Sasparilla receptors because there's a lot of it flowing and the cell doesn't want to waste it!

But having all those Sasparilla receptors crowds out the receptors for enthusiasm, curiosity or anything else. The cell covered with Sasparilla receptors won't be able to recognize Sunny Delight ® or Pepsi®.

Pretty soon those Sasparilla receptors start DEMANDING their favorite drink by releasing a chemical message of their own. The brain gets the message, "More Sasparilla! More Sasparilla!" So it reactivates the thought network that produces Sasparilla.

This is why you're still reliving drama from work three hours after you're home. Or why you're still worrying about money even if you have a steady income. And it's also the reason specific porn images show up repeatedly in your mind. Your brain cells are demanding their favorite beverage!

Unfortunately, just knowing intellectually what's going on in your head will have NO impact on your behavior.

In a perfect world, you would have learned all this brain chemistry stuff BEFORE you developed a problem with porn, but since you're reading this, that's probably not an option for you. You may be thinking, "What if my brain has already been programmed? What if my cells are already demanding 'More

Sasparilla!’ Is there any way to break the power of pornados?”

I’m not going to lie to you. There are several steps to reprogramming your brain, and they are all hard.

~~~

Chapter 5: Rewiring Your Brain

On their first date, Trevor's current girlfriend said "Any guy who looks at porn is disgusting," and she would never go out with a guy like that. So, right from the start, Trevor lied about who he is and the porn he looks at every day.

We've already established that every pornographic image you've ever seen is permanently burned into your brain's hard drive. It will always be there, and there will always be a pathway leading to it, whether you want one or not. Thoughts or images you have used repeatedly, have a track like a six-lane superhighway straight to Pleasure City. It won't go away.

However, you can reroute the traffic so that road gets overgrown. But don't kid yourself, just because you're not currently using it, it can still spring back to life in a heartbeat. There will always be a superfast connection to that exit. Your goal is to coax your brain into WANTING to take another exit. Let's break this down into steps.

Step ONE: Recognize the moment the urge appears.

Identify the trigger. There may be a legitimate cause for experiencing negative emotions like fear, anxiety or anger. A valid reason to do something about it. It's normal to want to feel better if your boss just chewed you out!

Immediately re-label the problem as chemical/neurological. “My brain cells are demanding the chemical fix associated with porn, because I feel unfairly attacked.”

This should feel similar to recognizing your bladder is full when you’re not near a bathroom. You may have a biological need to urinate, but it’s just not an option at the moment. Step One is a lot like redirecting your thoughts toward something else to take the focus off needing to pee.

Step TWO: Physically change locations.

Every step toward porn has to be detoured in your brain, so GET UP! Go outside, go to another room. If you are lying down, sit up. If you are sitting, stand up.

The minute the urge comes on, go for a run, shoot some hoops or bicycle -- anything that's physical and works up a sweat. Even if it's 4 am. This actively trains your brain to associate endorphin release with another behavior. It literally creates new neural pathways in the brain.

It's very important that you DON'T tell yourself, to “just wait it out.” In the first place, because you become more vulnerable every minute, and in the second place because waiting doesn't have any impact on your brain. The objective is to physiologically change your neural networks and receptors.

Step THREE: Change your internal dialogue.

Even small changes in your thoughts and “self-talk” make changes in your brain. If you started looking at porn, but within ten minutes you chose to stop, reward your brain by saying, “I got out MUCH quicker than last time!”

What counts is not the “success” of every attempt, but the consistency of the effort you’re making. Don’t beat yourself up and don’t give up.

Step FOUR: Start listing things in your life that you value or are grateful for.

Say it out loud, or type it into an email to yourself. “I’m grateful for double caramel macchiatos, for the view out this window, for a good night sleep, for Assassins Creed, for this cool new ringtone, etc.”

This is your Anti-Brat! It’s very hard to convince yourself you’re a victim when you realize you have many things to be grateful for.

Steps ONE through FOUR might look like this:

>>>You’re bored. You say, “My brain cells are demanding porn because they have nothing better to do.”

>>>You step outside and do 10 push-ups.

>>>You congratulate yourself. “Not bad! Ten pushups instead of porn feels

pretty good.”

>>>Dear Self: I’m glad for my HD monitor, my new Air Jordans, and that I put gas in my car before the price went up. Send.

The whole process takes less than 5 minutes, but reroutes neural traffic immediately. Follow up with Step FIVE.

~~~

## **Chapter 6: Brain Changer Toolkit**

*Louis considered it “playful” to tease his female coworkers about sex. In porn, the women “like it.” But in real life, they don’t. His employer got sued for sexual harassment, and Louis lost his job.*

\*\*\*

Until you get the hang of it, the first Four Steps will probably feel like grinding the gears in your transmission. The key to successful rerouting is...

Step FIVE: Engage in a pleasurable activity from your Brain Changer Toolkit.

Substitute your immediate urge for porn with something else. Your cells will physically respond to the new stimulation and start producing neuroreceptors associated with the new pleasure. You’ll feel content and your brain can repair your satisfaction hormones.

To do this, you’ll need to make a Brain Changer Toolkit. This is similar to what moms do to distract small children in waiting rooms and restaurants. You’re going to package together some easily accessible things that you enjoy in a Ziploc® bag: a favorite song or puzzle, a handheld video game, an expensive treat.

You will need more than one toolkit. Keep one at home, another at work, one in the car, etc. Each toolkit should have options for instantaneous distraction, as well as something which takes time to really immerse.

The broader your palette of options, the easier it will be to find the ideal activity in those red hot moments when you need it most.

To illustrate how this works, I'll use a piece of Godiva chocolate (the 4th most expensive chocolate in the world).

You don't just pop it in your mouth. This isn't "feeding the beast to numb the pain." It's meant to be a slow, indulgent moment of bliss. Be mindful of that little square. Smell it, look at it intently, touch it. Make a game of how many slivers you can shave off it. Then let it melt on your tongue. Breathe in the chocolate scent filling your nose. Give yourself up to the sensory indulgence of one little square of chocolate.

Another activity would be a Match Card Game, where the cards are pairs of pictures. You can get a deck in a toy store, but if you plan to use this at work or school you might want to make your own deck out of trading cards. As long as there are two of each.

Lay ten to twelve cards face down in front of you. Set a timer for 60 seconds. Turn over any two cards. If they match, put them aside. If they don't, turn them face down again. Your objective is to find as many "matches" as possible in one minute. Repeat several times, if you can.

The more senses you can engage, the better. The card matching activity engages eyes, hands, ears and memory. If you add finding as many matches as possible before an M&M melts in your mouth, even better!

Whatever the Brain Changer Activity is, make it the complete focus of your

attention, while telling yourself it is a reward for choosing a behavior that is not porn. Those thoughts will produce new neurotransmitters which will in turn produce new receptors.

Constantly add to your Toolkits. Toss in new or unfamiliar things because the brain loves variety. If an activity loses its juice, leave it aside for a while and try something else.

Having a Brain Changer Toolkit will provide immediate distraction, but it will take more than that to go the distance.

~~~

Chapter 7: Don't Do It Alone

Lucas never told his bride-to-be that he looked at porn for fear she wouldn't marry him. But she found out on their honeymoon. He left the hotel to get them something to eat while she prepared for romance on his return. He was gone a very long time. She went looking for him, and found him in the hotel gift shop, flipping through porn magazines.

As with other addictive behavior, few people overcome a destructive habit by themselves. It takes an accountability partner. Someone you can trust. Someone who isn't afraid to look you in the eye and ask the hard questions, but who will also be quick to encourage you to start over after you fail (and you WILL fail!)

Since MOST men struggle with porn at some point in their lives, you can assume practically every guy you know will understand what you're going through. However, don't be accountable to someone like your dad or a pastor. The need to preserve those relationships can produce deceptive behavior. (Seriously, what if you are financially dependent on your dad or you need a character reference from your pastor?)

If you can't think of a suitable person right away, make it a goal to find someone as soon as possible. Set a date to have one, and prepare a special Brain Changer Activity for when it is accomplished.

Use your accountability partner to bolster your weakest times.

What time of day are you the most vulnerable? If it's late at night, then plan an

alternative behavior like working out before bed, or walking your dog, even something simple like juggling hacky sacks! If your accountability partner can join you, perfect. If not, arrange a quick check-in before or after you walk the dog or juggle.

When/where is your easiest access? If you use porn instead of studying, break your study periods into short blocks of time with Brain Changers in between subjects. Set up a phone chat, Skype or have a text check-in during those breaks.

Talk to your accountability partner about the people in your life. Who encourages you to use porn? Get another man's input about which friendships are likely to move you toward your goal and which ones will pull you away.

Check-ins don't have to be long drawn out recitals of failure. Basically, you're looking for someone to ask, "Where have your eyes been?" It is KNOWING they're going to ask you that question which will eventually inspire you to choose a different behavior. Within a short time, your brain will start demanding you do the things that provide encouragement for victories.

And please make sure the focus of your check-in is on victories. Having an accountability partner won't work if every conversation just makes you feel worse!

Even if you only managed to redirect yourself ONCE after getting sucked into a pornado three times, still spend the majority of your check-in celebrating the one success and not the three defeats.

The objective is to get your brain to substitute positive thoughts to promote

physiological changes.

And the final key of reprogramming is: Focus on a Big Picture Goal.

~ ~ ~

Chapter 8: Fight FOR Something

Leo put \$1,000 in a bank account on the condition that if he could go 90 days without looking at porn, he would get the money back, but if he failed, it went to charity. He made it 87 days before he gave in. Even though he calls himself a tightwad, he confessed, "It could have been \$100,000 and I wouldn't be able to do it." Fear and punishment were very poor motivators.

A man fighting the seduction of porn feels weak and will grab ahold of any short-term fix. He believes all he has to do is keep from crossing the point of no return. And many quick-fixes do work... temporarily. But serious reprogramming will take more than a quick fix.

You need a Big Picture Goal (BPG).

It must be something as real to you as a medical degree or Olympic Gold. Something you would be willing to make great sacrifices to have or achieve.

Here a few examples:

>>>A loving relationship with someone who believes in you even when you stop believing in yourself.

>>>Confidence that you CAN resist temptation when you swear on your wedding day, "I will never cheat on you."

>>>Gaining the respect or admiration of your role model.

>>>Being coached in your favorite sport by your hero.

>>>Getting a merit promotion over more senior employees.

>>>Restoring trust to a broken relationship.

A BPG can be anything worth some emotional or physical distress!

When you have identified your BPG, flesh it out with your accountability partner. Write down every detail you can think of, and get to know it as well as you know where you live. Review it regularly, and update it as needed.

When you have the BPG clear in your mind, make a list of what it will take to achieve. This illustration might help.

Imagine a rich benefactor promises to give you your The Car of Your Dreams (whatever that is) completely paid for, plus the insurance and gas for two years... all you have to do to get it is give up watching television for a year.

No cheating by watching favorite shows with Hulu or On Demand. Total disconnection from any cable or TV show for 365 days.

If you took on this challenge, there are some obvious things you would do to increase your chances of success.

>>>Get rid of the TVs.

>>>Ask friends to help you.

>>>Have alternate activities planned.

>>>Practice what you'll say about why you're cutting out TV.

>>>Plaster your residence with pictures of the dream car.

>>>>>Read up on the car's options and features.

>>>Go for a test drive when your commitment wavers.

>>>Formulate a backup strategy for the unexpected (because TVs are everywhere!)

All of those steps would be practical and necessary, right?

Great! Now do the same thing for Your BPG of Life-Without-Porn.

>>>Get rid of the portals (physically move your computer to a common area or load up on blocking apps).

The more barriers the better! For instance, a lockout app that requires you to physically retrieve a password from someone else. On top of that install a keystroke tracker for your accountability partner to monitor.

Every additional hoop you have to jump through to gain access to porn is another opportunity to change your mind. When access is blocked by only one step, it's easy to find a workaround without much effort.

>>>Ask trusted friends to help. This has the added benefit of showing you who is a good influence and who isn't.

>>>Have alternate activities planned in advance. Make a list of at least ten things you can do instead of looking at porn.

>>>Practice what to say about why you're not engaging in those behaviors before they ask!

>>>Put up photoshopped pictures of yourself reaching your BPG. Getting married, graduating with a degree, working in the career of your dreams, etc.

>>>Detail all the benefits of your Life-Without-Porn. Financial, relational, professional, emotional, the on your integrity, etc.

>>>Print up a list or make a voice recording. Read or listen to it over and over.

>>>Revive your commitment by talking to others who already have what you want (faithful relationship, ideal position at work, specialized skill, educational achievement, etc.) Do this often!

>>>Have a backup strategy for the unexpected! Stash an emergency Brain Changer Toolkit in your car or backpack.

When your thoughts and conversations focus on your BPG in vivid detail, your brain will create the pathways and the receptors that will keep you thinking about it. The more you think about it, the more your brain will want to think about it!

~~~

## **[Chapter 9: Don't Give Up](#)**

During the American Revolution, the USS Bonhomme Richard was attacked by a British warship named Serapis on September 23, 1779.

The Serapis emptied her entire broadside into the Richard. When the Richard returned fire, two of her eighteen-pounders burst, killing many of the gunners and blowing away part of the deck above.

As Serapis pounded the Richard, a French ship, the Alliance, arrived on the scene. The captain of the American ship assumed the Alliance would engage the British warship, as the French were allies... but alarmingly, the French vessel fired two broadsides into the American ship, and then sailed away.

A hole in her side caused the Richard to ride two feet lower in the water. Eighty of her 144 men were dead. The ship's deck was damaged and covered in debris. Through the smoke, the American flag could not be seen on the mainmast. Striking the colors, or lowering the flag, is the international signal for surrender.

The British captain called out to the Americans, "Do you yield? Have you struck your colors?"

Defiantly, Captain John Paul Jones snatched up the flag, nailed it to the mast, so it could NOT be lowered and hollered back, "I have not yet begun to fight!"

\*\*\*

What does that story have to do with overcoming porn?

The process of reprogramming your brain will feel like you are on the USS Bonhomme Richard. You will have some spectacular fails along the way. Things you try will blow up in your face. People you thought were allies only make your problem worse. There will be times when you feel utterly defeated. But the key is, don't give up! START OVER AGAIN.

Each small victory will move you one step closer to winning, becoming truly free from porn.

Remember, Every day is fresh with no mistakes in it! You can start over.

No man is a failure because he reaches for a goal and doesn't achieve it. A man is only a failure when he doesn't try at all.

If you were unsuccessful avoiding porn today, what did you learn about what didn't work for you? Did you wait too long before you attempted the Steps? Has a Brain Changer Activity lost its appeal? Were you around someone who doesn't support your Big Picture Goal?

If you can identify what tripped you up, then you can recognize and avoid it next time. Just like leveling up in a video game. So what if you "died" this time!? Now you know to avoid that trap when you play through the next round. Do you think of yourself as a failure when you "die" in-game as a newbie? Of course not! There's an expectation that there will be setbacks until you master the game.

Attack the challenge of rewiring your brain with that perspective. You didn't



develop your problem with porn overnight, so it's reasonable to expect it will take some time before you are really good at these new skills.

Just keep reminding yourself: Every day is fresh with no mistakes in it! I can start over.

~~~

Chapter 10: You Can't Disappoint God*

**This chapter is written from a Christian perspective. If that's not how you identify yourself, reading this chapter could help you assist someone who does.*

~*~*~

At a Pastor's convention, a preacher asked the hotel clerk if he could talk to him about Jesus. The man seemed open to a discussion, so the preacher suggested they meet for breakfast in the morning. The next day, the clerk told him, "You have nothing to offer me. The hotel is full of pastors and most of the rooms paid for porn last night."

No big surprise, Christians struggle with porn too. It's not uncommon for believers to feel like they can never repair their relationship with the Lord.

So let's start with an indisputable FACT: You can't disappoint God. God is omniscient. Your problem with porn isn't news to Him. He's not shocked or disappointed in you. If you know what it means to say Jesus is my Savior and Lord, then you must understand He chose to love you knowing in advance how you would use people made in His image for sex.

He knew about your porn use before He went to the cross. He didn't die for the sins of the world with the caveat, "My sacrifice is for everyone... except people with sexual sins."

So let's just be clear: struggling with porn, even having a porn addiction, doesn't cost anyone their salvation. The Lord knows everything you have done, what you are currently doing and even what you will do in the future and He decided to die for you anyway.

Second, when Jesus became your Savior and Lord, the same power that raised Him from the dead came to dwell in you. You may not know how that works exactly, but that doesn't mean it isn't true. The power and resources are THERE, even if you haven't quite figured out how to use them. (Don't feel bad. Read the Book of Acts. Jesus' disciples were just as uncertain about applying the power of the Holy Spirit as you are!)

Third, never forget you are in a Spiritual Battle with Earthly Consequences. Porn is a weapon used by the enemy of your soul. He wants you to be obsessed and addicted to pleasure! His plan is to use you to finance the destruction of millions of other lives.

Anything that keeps humans self-absorbed and intent on meeting their own needs, prevents them from accomplishing what they were created for.

And finally, porn destroys the only earthly representation of the heavenly truth.

In God's original design, sex was to be exclusively within a legal lifetime commitment, between one man and one woman, wholly submitted to His loving direction in their lives, faithfully and frequently enjoying the best sex there is.

His wedding gift was what the bible calls becoming "one-flesh." Complete transparency physically, emotionally and sexually. In old-fashioned language it

was translated “knowing and being known.” Not hiding anything at all about who you are and still being loved.

It is only that imagery which could embody His Great Love. He offered the gift of ONENESS as a reward for mirroring His example as the World’s Greatest Lover.

The most famous passage in the bible on marriage is Ephesians 5:25

Husbands, love your wives just as Christ loved the church and gave Himself up for her.

Just how did Jesus love His bride?

>>>He accepted LEGAL responsibility (He didn’t use her to meet His needs).

>>>He didn’t assert His RIGHTS to do whatever He wanted whenever He wanted.

>>>He chose what was BEST for His Beloved – even when it wasn’t what He wanted. (Pretty sure crucifixion wasn’t His first choice of the way to love His bride.)

>>>He was willing to give up everything, up to and including His life, for her.

>>>He chose to ACT loving even when He didn't FEEL loved.

>>>He continued to love in spite of both physical pain and emotional abandonment.

Pretty high standard, isn't it?!

If the one thing Christians were known for was faithful happy marriages, with great sex, and the unconditional love of someone who wanted to grow old and wrinkly together, it would be so appealing non-believers would be compelled to ask, "I want what you have... how do I get that?"

Except that isn't the one thing Christians are known for.

Still, YOU could be a shining example.

Christian men who can claim long term success over porn, worked really hard at surrendering control of everything to God. They completely let go of their friends, their life and their defiance of God. Their abandon was so deep it changed their identity. And they emerged as a new person.

To gain this new identity requires commitment to a lifestyle that looks fanatic or extreme to outsiders. Praying every day. Reading His Word every day. Choosing only worship music. Inviting God's thoughts to drip into and overtake your thoughts, speech, behavior and actions.

Resting everything (both fears and hopes!) on the foundation of these truths:

>>>God is the same yesterday, today and forever. (Hebrews 13:8)

>>>You are the pinnacle of His creation. (Ephesians 2:10)

>>>He chased you through eternity to have an intimate relationship with you. (Romans 8:19-22)

>>>Nothing can separate you from His Great Love. (Romans 8:38-39)

As those truths seep into you, God will replace your poisonous view of sex with a healthy one.

Acquiring your soul-deep understanding of the unwavering love of God will eventually give you confidence. You won't go back, because you won't want to. Porn will be unappealing and undesirable.

It is possible to be as certain of that as you're sure now you won't stick your hand in a band saw!

By the power of the Holy Spirit, you can master the selfish part of your nature. The part of you using people for sex, and the part of you manipulating others to

get what you want.

You can reprogram yourself not to use other people to meet your needs.

You can stop giving yourself permission to engage in sexual gratification which “technically” doesn’t cross the biblical line (i.e.; masturbation, porn or non-vaginal intercourse).

You can acknowledge sexual desire is a powerful force, but decide to stop letting it run your life!

You can practice until you’re skilled at behaviors which reroute the stuff burned into your brain’s hard-drive.

You can immerse yourself in the Word of God so that it crowds out everything else.

You can know at the very core Who You Are In Christ.

And you can PRAY. But not just for yourself. You can pray for the people you use through porn. It doesn’t have to be a long or complicated prayer. Make it simple:

God bless her and give her what she needs. Whatever I am looking for in her, may I find it in You.

God is faithful to honor prayers like that because it conforms to His will – you are asking for what He already wants to give!

If you are unable to find an accountability partner or you need more help, you can confidentially and safely reach out to XXXChurch.com or RestoringHope.net. Both are Christian ministries for believers who struggle with pornography.

There are also very good books dealing with this topic written by Christians for Christians.

Millions of men have been helped by, Every Man's Battle: Winning the War on Sexual Temptation and Every Young Man's Battle by Stephen Arterburn (Doubleday Publishing 2000).

For more information about how the brain works, I recommend Hooked: New Science on How Casual Sex is Affecting Our Children by Drs. Joe S. McIlhaney, Jr. and Freda McKissic Bush (Northfield Publishing 2008).

[Covenant Eyes is one of many effective porn-blocking apps. Other resources related to healthy relationships and sexual self-control are also available at my website PositivelyWaiting.com](#)

If you want additional help, email justask@positivelywaiting.com

There may always be consequences from porn in your life, but it doesn't mean you are unworthy of being loved. No matter where you are in the process, no matter how many times you have failed, it's still true:

Every day is fresh with no mistakes in it! You can start over.

###

Thank you for reading my book! If you found it helpful, will you please leave a comment on the Positively Waiting Facebook Page?

All the best,

Karen

Discover other ebooks by Karen Kropf

[*Raising Teens With Sexual-Self Control: A Parent's Survival Guide*](#)

Sex Makes People Stupid: How to Avoid Ending Up With a Loser

Connect with Karen Kropf

www.PositivelyWaiting.com